INTRODUCTION

Improving living standards for mankind has been the single minded goal of all nations and world bodies. After defining development in numerous ways for over two decades, there seems to be a consensus on 'Human Development'. While a large popnlation on the earth is still to get the 'bare minimum' for development, humanity is at the crossroads where it is faced with the first of its kind challenge – the challenge of 'climate change'. The dilemma is that whatever we can do for our development, there has to be a repercussion on nature. An even bigger dilemma is in achieving a global consensus on how to check or restrict and finally reverse the process of climate change.

We may consider the year 2012, arguably, a high water mark in the field of environment and sustainable development initiatives. The global community met at the *UN Conference on Sustainable Development* that took place in **Rio** in June 2012, also marking the 20th anniversary of the first Earth Summit held in 1992. The Conference reviewed the progress made, identified implementation gaps, and assessed new and emerging challenges, which resulted in a political outcome called the *'The Future We Want'*. In India, the Twelfth Five Year Plan was launched with a focus on sustainable growth. This along with sustainable development policies and programmes which are being followed signalled to citizens at home and the world at large that India is committed to sustainable development with equal emphasis on its three dimensions - social, economic, and environmental.

A survey of the global comparative opinion shows that people in India and indeed all countries, have a marked and rising concern about sustainable development and climate change *(cited by the Economic Survey 2012-13)*. However, the challenges are also formidable, especially in the context of finding the matching resources of the required magnitude given the economic conditions. Climate science has rightly taken up an important position in the public debate. Even as the science of climate change grapples with uncertainties, the world is witnessing more extreme events. The urgency for action is felt more than ever before. In contrast, though the Doha, Gateway on climate change in December 2012 agreed upon a